

THE SENIOR CLUB

At 70 years and above, this cohort may have made a late debut, but it is accompanied by a wealth of experience





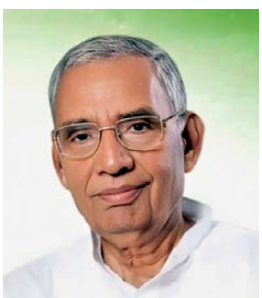
▲ NALIN SOREN, *76*

| JMM | *Dumka (ST), Jharkhand*

As a seven-term MLA from Sikaripara and a contemporary of Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) patriarch Shibu Soren, this seasoned tribal leader's political journey—which started from the undivided Bihar—has been marked by loyalty and rigour. Though only four years younger to Shibu, Nalin idolises him and has remained steadfastly loyal to him and his son Hemant. Nalin's Lok Sabha win has been celebrated across the party cadre because he has not only reclaimed Dumka, a seat previously held by Shibu, but also because he defeated Sita Soren, Hemant's estranged sister-in-law who joined the BJP ahead of the election.

▼ BRIJENDRA SINGH OLA, *72*

| CONGRESS | *Jhunjhunu, Rajasthan*



A postgraduate in political science from Rajasthan University, Ola lived up to the legacy of his father—the late Jat stalwart and former Union minister Shish Ram—as he won Jhunjhunu assembly seat for fourth time in a row in 2023 before winning the parliamentary seat this year. This former transport minister in the Ashok Gehlot regime is close to Sachin Pilot, who during his stint as the Rajasthan Congress chief had stayed in his MLA accommodation in Jaipur for five years. It was on Pilot's call that Ola agreed to contest the Lok Sabha election after publicly expressing his unwillingness, and went on to wrest the seat held by his father for five terms from the BJP after a decade.

▶ PHANI BHUSAN CHOUDHURY, *72*

| AGP | *Barpeta, Assam*

A former teacher, this Asom Gana Parishad leader has occupied the Bongaigaon assembly seat for an uninterrupted four decades and became a minister in the BJP-led state government in 2018. Known for his austere living, he used to often visit schools in his constituency to teach children or could be seen getting a haircut from a roadside barber or hitchhiking on two-wheelers.

